Similarly, Israel's center-left parties focused on the economy and social issues, believing they would resonate with voters. They didn't. The center-left bloc actually shrank, from 46 seats to 40, and Netanyahu (who didn't even bother drafting an economic platform) pulled out a surprise victory on a last-minute appeal to security interests and Jewish tribalism.

The morning after Israel's election, I went down to a cafe below my apartment to file some early copy. A man at the next table was tossing back shots at 9 am. The waitress was in tears. "I can't believe it," she said. "I don't know anyone who voted Likud." I heard the same from British friends following the referendum, and from Americans in the aftermath of the presidential election. Across the world, it seemed, liberals were waking up to the realization that large parts of their own countries were foreign territory.

The West

Historians will no doubt spend the next few decades arguing over what caused this lurch toward right-wing populism. Was it a working-class backlash against globalization and neoliberal economics? A response to the fear and uncertainty caused by Islamist militants across the globe? The last gasp of an older, white, Christian majority in an increasingly multicultural West?

This book does not have the answer (though I would lean towards "all of the above"). Viewed from the Middle East, though—where questions of identity are omnipresent—the last point seems to merit particular scrutiny. The countries of Western Europe and North America, to greater or lesser extents, are caught in a painful transition between two models of identity: a narrow one, rooted in shared language or culture or skin color; and a broader one, tied to a loose social contract. Immigration was the animating issue for many Brexit supporters, and for Le Pen's base. Xenophobia was an inseparable part of the Trump campaign.

Israel's identity is simultaneously drawn from both of these models, and from neither. The Jewish population is bound together by Jewish tradition, in a way that America's assimilated and cosmopolitan Jews increasingly are not. Yet an identity based on Judaism excludes one-fifth of the population—so Israel also offers a social contract, granting a degree of autonomy in religious and communal affairs within the broader framework of a liberal